

CDN Incident Alert: 0041. TLP: CLEAR			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	DE	Sky's the Limit - Russian Influence Operation Doppelgänger Expands to Bluesky	27/01/2025	2

Summary

- On January 17, more than 100 German language Doppelgänger accounts become active on Bluesky, replying to posts by authentic users. During the same period, posts in English, Polish, French, and Turkish also appeared.
- The influence operation focused on narratives discrediting Ukraine and the German traffic light coalition.
- The operation published over 4900 posts between January 17th and 24th, likely having limited impact.
- Doppelgänger's key TTPs on Bluesky include bulk creating accounts, posting inauthentic social media comments, using local personas, and concealing Russian sponsorship of their activity.
- The pattern of behaviour of Doppelgänger can be used to track it and stop it from operating.

Incident

On January 17, more than 100 German language Bluesky accounts likely belonging to the Russian Doppelgänger influence operation started replying to other users' posts. The replies contained either only text or also memes. They used a small variety of narratives discrediting Ukraine and the traffic light coalitions policies. The replies were to seemingly random users writing in German.

Between the 17th and 20th of January, these accounts published a few replies a day before stopping. On January 23rd, a small subsection of these accounts started publishing hundreds of replies each day.

While this study focused on Germany, what seems like Doppelgänger accounts also posted in English, French, Polish, and Turkish.

Narrative

Economic and Political Decline in Germany and Europe; Criticism of Political Leadership and Systems of Germany; Opposition to Current Foreign Policy of Germany; US Influence and Exploitation of Germany and EU.

Impact

33 accounts that remained online until January 20. These only published a few posts a day, reaching 667 posts in total. 4300 posts were posted by the second smaller batch of accounts that posted hundreds of replies each day. The impact of the posts is as of yet likely limited. We could not identify any meaningful interactions with the operation. The influence operation is still likely in an early phase of development.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

- [Degrading](#) - the image of Ukraine, the Ukrainian people, and the national leaders supporting them;
- [Discouraging](#) - the targeted countries from supporting Ukraine.
- [Bulk Created Asset](#) – the accounts were created and activated around the same time frames
- [Post Inauthentic Social Media Comment](#) - the influence operation spreads its content by commenting on other users' posts to reach its target audience.
- [Local Persona](#) – the influence operation mimics German citizens.
- [Conceal Sponsorship](#) - the influence operation hides its true identity and financial connection to Russia.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Reported pages to Bluesky, journalists, and European governments;

Recommendations: Bluesky can use the pattern of behaviour of the influence operation described in our report to mitigate it; Researchers should monitor the development of the operation on the platform.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	Logo
Link	Ukraine, Doppelgänger, Election.	Hunchly files available upon request	Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe. Karolin Schwarz, Independent.	Bluesky	